



An Roinn Breisoideachais agus Ardoideachais,
Taighde, Nuálaíochta agus Eolaíochta
Department of Further and Higher Education,
Research, Innovation and Science

National Student Accommodation Strategy 2026–2035



Prepared by the Department of Further and Higher Education, Research, Innovation and Science
[gov.ie](https://www.gov.ie)

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Foreword

I am pleased to publish the **second National Student Accommodation Strategy for Ireland’s higher education sector**. This Strategy is a key pillar of the Government’s wider plan to boost housing supply and ensure that our students have access to affordable, high-quality accommodation.



Since the first strategy was introduced in 2017, 16,266 purpose built student accommodation beds have been completed nationwide, bringing the total stock to over 49,000. As of December 2025, a further 2,379 beds are under construction, 14,279 have planning permission, and 678 are in the planning system.

The Sector has seen sustained growth in student numbers alongside significant challenges in the construction sector. The combined impacts of Brexit, the COVID-19 pandemic, the war in Ukraine and interest rate increases have disrupted supply chains, slowed delivery of Purpose Built Student Accommodation, and challenged the viability of Purpose Built Student Accommodation (PBSA) developments. This updated Strategy responds to those challenges with a clear, practical roadmap for the decade ahead.

The Strategy sets out a balanced and ambitious approach, including:

- **The commitment to long term State-backed measures to activate supply**, working in partnership with the private sector.
- **Affordability supports for students**, providing equity of access.
- **Support for development of accommodation on public campuses as well as on private sites** near to campus.
- **Expansion of the Technological Sector Student Accommodation programme** to include traditional universities, enabling the sector as a whole to meet demand.

Over the lifetime of this Strategy, we aim to deliver **42,000 additional beds by 2035** through public and private PBSA and Rent-a-Room accommodation. This expansion will provide students with greater access to affordable, high-quality housing, reduce pressure on the rental market, and create a more supportive living environment that enhances their academic experience.

A strong emphasis on **standardised design** reflects what students have told us: they want **simple, affordable accommodation located on or near their chosen higher education institution**. *The Design Guide for State Sponsored Student Accommodation* when applied to our student accommodation programme will enable efficient delivery of high-quality student accommodation to meet the needs of our students. This principle is central to the Strategy’s objectives.

Affordability remains a cornerstone of this Strategy, and it aligns with the **National Access Plan**, promoting equity of access to higher education for underrepresented groups, including lower income groups, those with disabilities and minority communities. Targeted financial supports will be available to students regardless of whether they live at home, in Rent-a-Room, private rental, or PBSA.

This **Strategy is practical, collaborative, and achievable**. By working with key public and private stakeholders, we will deliver actions that support development of sufficient purpose built student accommodation, expansion of Rent-a-Room options, and advancement of HEI led sustainable commuting strategies with the aim of meeting students’ needs in the medium and long term.

James Lawless TD

Minister for Further and Higher Education, Research, Innovation and Science

I welcome the publication of the **National Student Accommodation Strategy 2026–2035**. This is a significant and positive step forward for our students and for regional development across Ireland.



I am particularly pleased to see proposals for the delivery of new student accommodation for our **Technological Universities and Institutes of Technology** in the regions.

This Strategy is about more than bricks and mortar – it is about creating opportunity and ensuring fairness. By providing **affordable supports for students and supporting the development of new student accommodation**, we make it possible for students from rural Ireland to study at their regional university without the burden of relocating to a major city. That matters, because **education should be within reach for everyone, no matter where they live**.

Accommodation on or near campus also makes our Technological Universities more attractive to students, supporting Government goals for **balanced regional growth and innovation beyond the major cities**.

I look forward to seeing the successful rollout of the expanded **Technological Sector Student Accommodation Programme**, which will deliver the much-needed housing for students across Ireland and help secure a brighter future for our regions.

Marian Harkin TD

Minister of State for
Further Education, Apprenticeship,
Construction and Climate Skills,
Department of Further and Higher Education,
Research, Innovation and Science

1. Executive Summary

The National Student Accommodation Strategy sets out a pathway to make higher education more accessible by addressing two critical challenges, accommodation affordability and accommodation supply and viability. It does so in the context of a projected requirement for approximately 42,000 student beds by 2035.

This projection includes an existing deficit of 15,000 beds which is currently contributing to unsustainably long commuting patterns for some students. Recognising the challenges faced in the wider housing market, the strategy also aims to meet the emerging demand of 42,000 without any additional recourse to the private rental sector.

The strategy is informed by the Short-Term Activation programme which has now concluded with development of almost 1,000 Purpose Built Student Accommodation (PBSA) beds in train supported by circa €110 million in NDP funding, with 30% of the beds provided at discounted rents to support affordability.

The key lessons from that programme are that:

- The scale of funding required to meet the projected level of future and unmet existing demand is far in excess of the States funding capacity, and private sector funding and development will be required in addition to an increased focus on Rent-a-Room accommodation
- Directly funding PBSA limits the impact of the funding to a small group of students. A more comprehensive set of affordability measures would better support all students experiencing accommodation related affordability challenges, regardless of where they live, whether in public or private PBSA, the private rental sector, rent a room accommodation, or at home.

The strategy will be delivered through two pillars, supply and viability, and affordability

Efforts to strengthen the supply and viability of projects are being addressed through fiscal and regulatory reforms to enhance the attractiveness of the PBSA market.

In addition, an innovative approach to supporting the development of on or near campus PBSA through the Higher Education Sector Student Accommodation Programme is complemented by the promotion of Rent-a-Room accommodation as an additional accommodation option for students.

Rental reforms and reductions to VAT from 13.5% to 9% on sale of PBSA will stimulate new PBSA development including some of the 14,279 beds which currently have planning permission but are not being developed.

Development of a student accommodation programme supported by the Higher Education Authority (HEA) and the National Development Finance Agency (NDFA) is underway.

This programme will enable Higher Education Institutions (HEIs) to have access to increased PBSA beds by supporting private developers to build PBSA on or near campus through a combination of nomination agreements, licensed sites and site servicing.

- A nomination agreement involves a commitment by the Higher Education Institution to nominate students for an agreed number of PBSA beds in a private development for an agreed period (usually circa 5 years). A borrowing framework will be provided to Technological Universities subject to the sanction of the Minister for Finance and the Minister for Public Expenditure, Infrastructure, Public Service Reform and Digitalisation to enable them to enter into such agreements.
- Licensing of sites on campus by HEIs will enable private developers to build and operate PBSA on a university campus for the period of the licence (usually circa 60 years). The PBSA would return to HEI ownership on expiry of the 60-year period.
- State supported site servicing involves the provision of surveys to establish ground conditions together with further enabling work on or adjacent to relevant sites.

Beds developed as part of this programme are being further supported through standardised PBSA designs which enable more cost-efficient development to optimise accommodation potential and avoid duplication through on site development which leverages existing campus amenities.

Technological Universities have already identified possible accommodation options which are being further developed to enable market engagement for both on and off campus PBSA development through Expressions of Interest in 2026 and formal tendering in early 2027. The programme is being expanded to include traditional universities and will be delivered in a series of phases starting with Cork, Dublin and Galway and quickly followed by Waterford, Limerick and Athlone and subsequently Tralee, Carlow, Sligo, and Letterkenny. Subject to market response and HEI approval, construction is envisaged to begin from 2028.

Affordability is being addressed by providing financial supports directly to students via the Student Grant Scheme (SUSI) which targets students living 30km or more from their chosen HEI as well as continued support via the PATH 2 1916 bursary for the most socio-economically disadvantaged students and from groups most underrepresented in higher education. The Student Accommodation Assistance scheme targets Traveller, Roma and care-experienced students and the Student Assistance fund provides financial assistance to students experiencing difficulty with transport, rent and living expenses. These schemes combined provide €176 million in affordability supports annually and are complemented by the rent tax credit which provides up to €2,000 in credit annually for a jointly assessed couple or €1,000 for a single applicant. The credit is open to parents supporting a child with accommodation expenses including Rent-a-Room accommodation.

Implementation of the strategy will be overseen by an Inter Departmental Group to coordinate stakeholder engagement and review progress to ensure delivery of the actions and will be complemented by the development of HEI specific student accommodation strategies to ensure ownership at individual HEI level.

2. What the Strategy Means

Driving Ambition, Strategic Investments, Transformational Targets



New Student Beds

16,000+

Over 16,000 new student beds built since 2017



Increased Ambition with a Target of

42,000

Student beds by 2035



Short-Term Activation Programme

967

Beds delivered or progressing



Technological Sector Student Accommodation proposals being evaluated from;

- Technological University Dublin
- Munster Technological University
- Technological University of the Shannon: Midlands Midwest
- Atlantic Technological University
- South East Technological University
- Institute of Art, Design and Technology



Capital Exchequer Funding

€250m

Investment in student accommodation 2023-2030



DFHERIS Annual Direct Supports to Students

€176m

- SUSI (Non-Adjacent Grants)
- Student Assistance Fund
- Student Accommodation Assistance
- 1916 Bursary



Rent Tax Credit

315,030

Tax payers benefited in 2023 at a cost of €185.3 million



Rent-a-Room Relief Scheme

€14,000

Homeowners to earn up to €14,000 per annum



Investment support through Fiscal and Regulatory Reforms

- Rent Control
- Standards
- VAT Reduction

The Strategy is based on the twin pillars of Supply and Viability, and Affordability

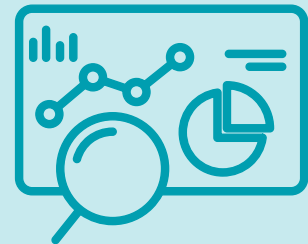
Supply and Viability of Projects

DFHERIS Viability Measures

- HEI Student Accommodation Programme on or near to campus PBSA
- Standardised Design and Modern Methods of Construction
- HEI owned land and site servicing
- Technological Universities borrowing capacity via nomination agreements
- Sustainable Commuting

Other Government Viability Supports

- Rent Reform
- Changes to VAT on sale of new apartments (including PBSA)
- Planning and Development (Amendment) Act 2025
- Rent-a-Room Relief Scheme



Affordability for Students

DFHERIS Annual Supports for Students

- Student Grant Scheme
- 1916 Bursary
- Short-Term Activation Programme
- Student Accommodation Assistance Scheme
- Student Assistance Fund
- Fund for Student with Disabilities

Other Government Affordability Supports

- Back to Education Allowance
- Aftercare Supports
- Rent Tax Credit

Student Wellbeing

- Voluntary Framework for Rent-a-Room Accommodation
- HEI pastoral care embedded in individual HEI accommodation policies
- Pilot programme to improve sustainable commuting options for students



3. Introduction and Context

A well-integrated student accommodation system is fundamental to fostering equity, access, and sustainability within Ireland’s higher education landscape.

Purpose Built Student Accommodation (PBSA), both on and off campus, alongside private rentals, Rent-a-Room accommodation in an owner-occupied property ('Rent-a-Room'), and Living at Home, collectively form the supply base of student housing. Ensuring this system functions effectively is critical to supporting student wellbeing, academic success¹, and long-term sector resilience.

According to the *Private Rental Sector Review*, rents have persistently risen in the past decade.² Given the sustained increase in rental costs across Ireland, the limited availability of student housing stock, and the high proportion of students reliant on the private rental sector³, there is a compelling case for expanding the provision of PBSA and Rent-a-Room accommodation. This expansion should be aligned with achieving sustainable commuting distance for students.⁴

Although there is demand from students and a strong appetite among accommodation providers and investors, the delivery of new student housing has fallen short of requirements. This shortfall is primarily driven by elevated construction costs⁵ which have significantly impacted project viability. The wider housing market is not delivering sufficient supply to meet demand. With planning permission for 14,279 student beds un-activated, the viability of the market is called into question. Delays within the broader planning system and the impact of rent caps have further hindered progress on proposed developments.⁶

This Strategy aims to support expansion of PBSA on publicly owned on-campus sites, and off campus, on privately owned sites and to increase uptake of Rent-a-Room accommodation. It also aims to increase the level of support provided to students to address affordability challenges.

3.1 Policy Objective and Target

The National Student Accommodation Strategy 2026–2035 supports access to appropriate housing for full-time undergraduate and postgraduate students attending publicly funded Higher Education Institutions.

The Strategy aims to increase the supply of new student accommodation beds and promote alternative housing options such as Rent-a-Room accommodation, to address the 42,000 additional student accommodation requirement emerging between now and 2035 without increasing reliance on the private rental sector. This will be achieved through viability measures and affordability supports, including assistance for students identified under the National Access Plan. The Strategy attempts to balance the tension between rent levels required to achieve viability and supports required to enable affordability.

¹ 'Research internationally (Pascarella and Terenzini 2005; Thomas 2012 as quoted by Gormley 2015 P.1) has shown that students living in on-campus accommodation have higher retention rates than commuter students and also exhibit higher scores on developmental scales (Chickering and Reisser, 1993 as quoted by Gormley 2015 P.1)'. Report On Student Accommodation: Demand & Supply, HEA, 2015 available at <https://hea.ie/assets/uploads/2017/06/Report-on-Student-Accommodation-Demand-Supply.pdf>

² Private Rental Sector Review, published by the Department of Housing, Local Government and Heritage, July 2024 available at <https://assets.gov.ie/static/documents/private-rental-sector-review.pdf>

³ Student Survey, HEA, 2024

⁴ Report On Student Accommodation: Demand & Supply, HEA, 2015 available at <https://hea.ie/assets/uploads/2017/06/Report-on-Student-Accommodation-Demand-Supply.pdf>

⁵ Commercial construction inflation stabilised at 3% annually, down from a recent high of 11.5% in 2022. Society of Chartered Surveyors Ireland, February, 2025 available at <https://scsi.ie/press-release-commercial-construction-tender-prices-increased-by-1-5-in-the-second-half-of-2024/>

⁶ Purpose-Built Student Accommodation Market Outlook 2024, Lisney, January 2024

Alignment with Department of Further and Higher Education Research Innovation and Science (DFHERIS) Strategy

As part of the Department’s aim to provide high quality accessible tertiary education, the Department commits to supporting a high-performing, inclusive and future-focused tertiary education system that delivers for learners, the economy and society. An integral part of this commitment is an intention to support the development and implementation of a long-term student accommodation strategy to address the availability and affordability of student accommodation.

3.2 Background and Rationale

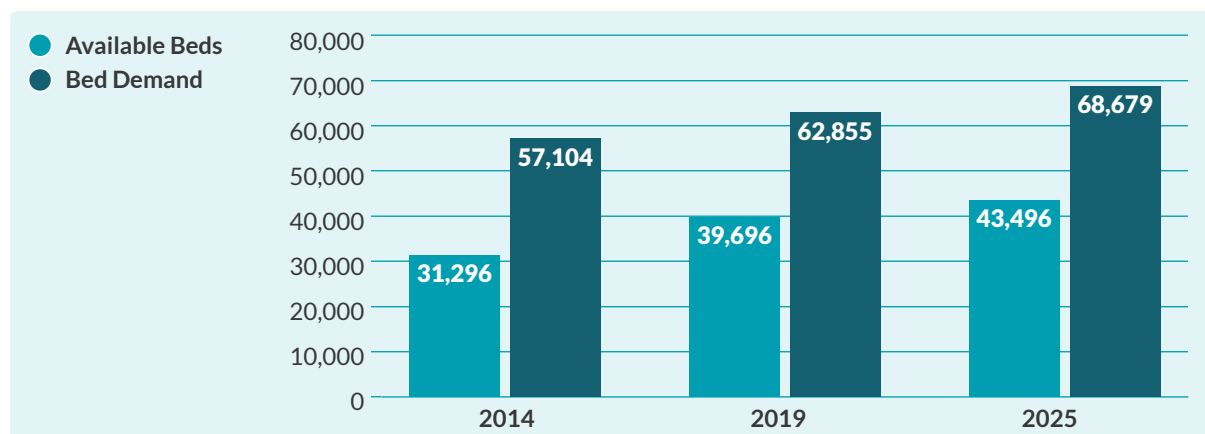
Students have traditionally relied on living at home, Private Rentals, and Rent-a-Room as sources of accommodation.

As demand for accommodation grew, universities began expanding on-campus housing, and by the 2010s the supply of PBSA had grown significantly, supported by investment from both institutions and private developers. Challenges arising from both direct and indirect construction costs have now constrained supply, preventing it from keeping pace with growing demand and as a result, affordability has deteriorated.

National Student Accommodation Strategy (NSAS) (2017–2024)

In 2015, the HEA published its *Report on Student Accommodation: Demand and Supply from 2015 to 2024*.⁷ It identified an unmet demand of about 25,000 bed spaces due to enrolment growth and insufficient supply. This data (Figure 1) was based on current and projected development of student accommodation.

Figure 1. Supply and Demand for Student Bed Spaces 2014–2024



Informed by this analysis, the National Student Accommodation Strategy 2017-2024 (NSAS) set a target of an additional 21,000 PBSA beds and 4,000 Rent-a-Room beds by the end of 2024.

⁷ *Report on Student Accommodation: Demand & Supply*, HEA, 2015 available at <https://hea.ie/resources/publications/report-on-student-accommodation-demand-supply>
This HEA publication was a once-off report and the analysis was limited by the data available at that time, particularly in relation to the supply of private student accommodation

Figure 2. NSAS 2017–2024 PBSA Targets and Output

	Target	Output
Beds by 2019	7,000	8,000
Beds by 2024	21,000	16,000 by September 2025
Rent-a-Room	4,000	>5,400 beds advertised September 2025

Delivery of PBSA has experienced a slowdown in recent years, largely due to the lingering effects of the COVID-19 pandemic and a series of geopolitical disruptions, together with the impact of rent caps, planning challenges and the increased costs associated with rental outside of term time. These developments have further constrained development timelines and investment appetite across the sector, placing additional pressure on an already stretched housing system.

Demographic Projections

The Central Statistics Office projects an increase in overall population over the period from 5.2m people in 2023 to 5.8m in 2035.⁸ In line with this, HEA projections derived from HEI estimates of their future student populations submitted to the HEA in 2024, suggest that by 2034/2035 the number of undergraduate and postgraduate full-time students in publicly funded HEIs will grow by 41,000 to 243,499.

International students currently make up around 15% of this number and *Global Citizens 2030*⁹ positions Ireland as a top destination for international students, researchers, and innovators. Through Erasmus+, Ireland supports education exchanges across all levels. International student numbers have steadily grown over the past number of years apart from a dip during the Covid period.¹⁰

Technological Universities – The Regions

Established under the Technological Universities Act 2018, Technological Universities (TUs) provide programmes of education and training that reflect the needs of individuals, business, enterprise, the professions, the community, local interests, and other stakeholders in the regions and facilitate learning throughout life. The establishment of Technological Universities aligns with the government objective of balanced regional development. Prior to the establishment of Technological Universities, university education was concentrated in major urban areas. Technological Universities now occupy twenty-one university campuses across seventeen counties which provides a more balanced choice of study location for students, many of whom will be able to live at home and travel daily to university, thus reducing the reliance on accommodation in urban centres. Technological Universities are continuing to widen their range of courses and programmes including in areas such as Pharmacy and Veterinary Medicine.

The Strategy recognises the growth of Technological Universities within Higher Education and the need for PBSA development on or close to TUs. Addressing this housing need is essential to supporting equitable access to education and enhancing the student experience across all regions. Except for South East Technological University, which provides 426 beds, none of the other Technological Universities or Institutes of Technology have on-campus PBSA.

The combination of supply constraints together with the expanded Higher Education footprint following the establishment of Technological Universities and the growing demographic profile support the development of a new student accommodation strategy building on the achievements signalled in the 2017-2024 strategy.

⁸ CSO, Population and Labour Force projections 2023-2057

⁹ DFHERIS, January, 2024 <https://assets.gov.ie/static/documents/global-citizens-2030-irelands-international-talent-and-innovation-strategy.pdf>

¹⁰ HEA Statistics, available at <https://hea.ie/statistics/data-for-download-and-visualisations/key-facts-figures/>

3.3 Short-Term Activation Programme

In November 2022, the Government for the first time approved the development of a policy to provide State assistance to activate the development of new student accommodation for publicly funded HEIs.

The Short-Term Activation Programme (STAP) which has now concluded provided funding to HEIs to activate projects that had planning permission in place but could not be delivered due to viability issues, principally due to high development costs. The delivery of up to around 1,000 new PBSA beds is being progressed under this programme.

Thirty percent of the bed spaces delivered under this programme are being ringfenced at below market rates for targeted student groups identified in the National Access Plan (NAP).

Lessons Learned from the Short-Term Activation Programme

The STAP was a targeted emergency response to the acute shortage of student accommodation. Key lessons have emerged from the programme:

- The cost per bed under the programme indicates a funding level that would be untenable for the State, given the projected increase of 41,000 full-time students between 2025 and 2035 (*see market analysis*). The design specification of projects assessed varied considerably, suggesting the need for some form of standardisation.
- While the programme will provide reduced accommodation rates for approximately three hundred students, it does not address the broader affordability challenges facing the wider student population. The Strategy will therefore develop affordability levers independently of viability measures.
- A viability gap exists between the cost of delivering PBSA and the price that buyers or renters are willing or able to pay. This gap will need to be closed to enable the delivery of a pipeline of PBSA developments over the lifetime of the Strategy.

3.4 Development Costs and Standardised Design

The Student Accommodation Standardised Design Study aimed to develop new design standards for state-supported on or near campus housing. Its goal is to ensure best practice and value for money while increasing student housing supply.

Published in June 2025, *Design Guide for State Sponsored Student Accommodation*¹¹ follows a recommendation from the 2023 Residential Construction Cost Study.¹² These design standards now support the delivery of high-quality student accommodation by driving consistency in design, enhancing cost-efficiency, and facilitating the use of modern methods of construction. They allow for the provision of shared bathrooms and the reduced space per resident sharing kitchen, dining, and living spaces within clusters of 10 or more students. They seek to ensure value for money for the State while promoting the development of modern student residences that are functional, sustainable, maintainable, flexible, safe, and architecturally well-designed.

The Design Guide will inform future projects and seeks to enable efficient delivery of high-quality student accommodation to meet the needs of our students.

¹¹ DFHERIS, 2025, available at https://assets.gov.ie/static/documents/Design_Guide_for_State_Sponsored_Student_Accommodation.pdf

¹² DHLG, 2023, available at <https://assets.gov.ie/static/documents/residential-construction-cost-study-report.pdf>

3.5 Policy and Regulatory Framework

The Student Accommodation Strategy aligns with several broader national priorities, including:

- **The National Access Plan 2022–2028** as this Strategy directly addresses the affordability and availability of student housing.
- **Impact 2030: Ireland’s Research and Innovation Strategy; Global Citizens 2030: Ireland’s Talent and Innovation Strategy:**
Talent is central to Ireland’s research and innovation ecosystem, and DFHERIS is committed to attracting top researchers from diverse backgrounds, both domestically and internationally. The availability of high-quality, affordable student accommodation is a critical factor in attracting and retaining postgraduate researchers to HEIs.
- **Project Ireland 2040, National Development Plan, National Planning Framework:**
Publicly supported PBSA will support compact, sustainable, and balanced regional development by locating student housing in areas that strengthen communities and reduce pressure on adjacent housing markets.
- **Delivering Homes, Building Communities 2025–2030: An Action Plan on Housing Supply and Targeting Homelessness:**
Government is committed to a long-term student accommodation strategy focused on increasing the supply of student accommodation in line with demand.

The Student Accommodation Strategy is designed to complement and align with the objectives of the National Housing Plan, recognising that student accommodation is a critical component of the wider housing system. As such, the Strategy should be considered an integral part of national housing policy, contributing to the increased provision of student beds without increased reliance on the private rental market.

The *Review of Rent Pressure Zones*¹³ (RPZs) by the Housing Agency (2025) provides detailed insights into how RPZs have impacted the supply of rental housing, including PBSA, and outlines the importance of regulatory stability for developers and investors. Following the review, the Government approved new policies to strengthen rent controls and tenancy protections for new tenancies created from 1 March 2026. Students in existing PBSA will also continue to benefit from rent control protections for a further three years to 2029.

The growing demand for student accommodation is not unique to Ireland; it is an increasingly urgent issue across Europe. At EU level for the first time an EU Commissioner for Energy and Housing has been appointed.¹⁴ The Commission launched its first Housing Task Force to aid the Housing Commissioner and advance a **European Affordable Housing Plan** with related policies.¹⁵

Climate Action Plan, Moving Together – A Strategic Approach to the Improved Efficiency of the Transport System in Ireland. The Strategy contains a number of actions which focus the higher education system on reducing its emissions from transport. Student accommodation will be developed sustainably, in line with each higher education institution’s obligations under the Climate Action Plan.

¹³ The Housing Agency, 2025, available at www.housingagency.ie/sites/default/files/2025-06/Final%20Review%20RPZ%20and%20Policy%20Options%20for%20Rent%20Controls%20in%20PRs.pdf

¹⁴ Dan Jørgensen, European Commissioner for Energy and Housing: https://commission.europa.eu/about/organisation/college-commissioners/dan-jorgensen_en

¹⁵ The European Commission Housing Task Force was established in February 2025: https://housing.ec.europa.eu/contact-us_en

3.6 Programme for Government Commitments

The Strategy directly responds to the Government’s commitments outlined in *Programme for Government 2025: Securing Ireland’s Future*.

It supports the development of *“a multi-annual plan to urgently deliver new student accommodation, including through state financed purpose-built student accommodation on public or private lands.”*

The Strategy will explore, in limited circumstances and in line with affordability and appropriate controls, the capacity of *“Technological Universities to borrow funds to provide for on-campus student accommodation.”*

In addition, it will *“examine measures to boost the take-up of the Rent-a-Room Relief Scheme”* and commits to ensuring *“student accommodation leases align with the academic year, making it easier for students to secure housing only for the months they need.”* Complementary actions include increasing maintenance grants and continued investment in the Student Assistance Fund, further strengthening supports for students across the country.

4. Supply and Demand Analysis

In 2024 the HEA undertook a supply and demand analysis to inform the national strategy, examining the distinct sources of accommodation available to students, Public PBSA, Private PBSA, Rent-a-Room accommodation, Living at Home, and the Private Rental sector.

While the Strategy acknowledges the full spectrum of student housing options, it explicitly focuses its growth targets on Public PBSA, Private PBSA and Rent-a-Room accommodation and making commuting from home more sustainable. It does so without any increased recourse to private rental to help alleviate the housing pressures being experienced in that sector.

4.1 HEA Student Survey

Accommodation availability and affordability are having a direct influence on student decision-making and educational experience.

In this context the HEA, in conjunction with DFHERIS, undertook student surveys in both 2023 and 2024 to inform Government policy. There were 14,230 student responses in 2024 and 22,801 in 2023 representing 5% and 9% of the relevant student populations, respectively. Further surveys will be conducted periodically to ensure an up-to-date picture of student accommodation and commuting experience is captured.

Existing Accommodation Arrangements

The 2024 survey found that 36% of respondents were living in the family home, 16% were in on campus PBSA (HEI owned), 17% were in off campus PBSA (Privately owned), 18% were in private rental accommodation, 12% were in Rent-a-Room accommodation and 1% reported Living at Home while looking for accommodation. Students reported paying an average rent of €700 per month over the two surveys.

Commuting Travel Arrangements

In 2024, 18% of the students Living at Home had an hour and a half commute or more each way to college. The Strategy considers that such commutes are not sustainable and that student accommodation needs have not been met where commutes more than three hours round trip daily are required.

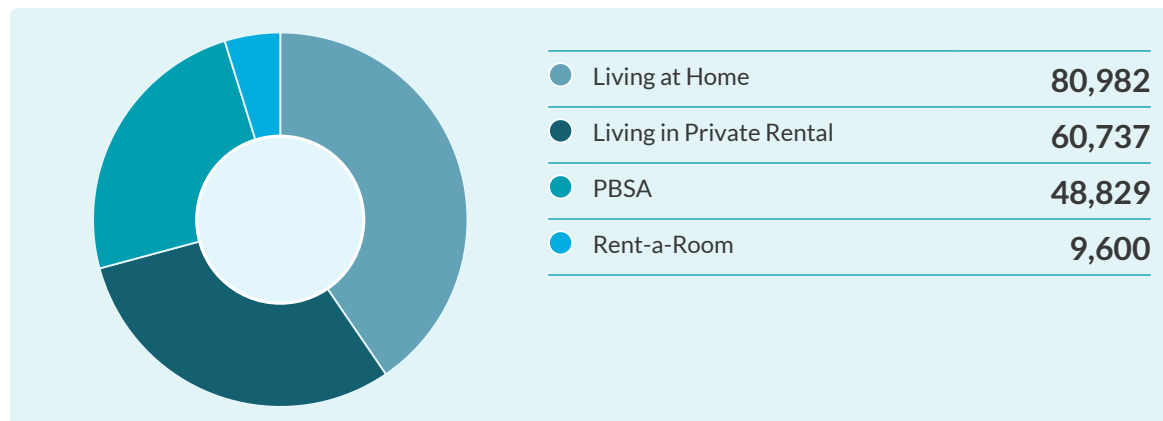
4.2 Supply and Demand: Estimates

The supply and demand estimates draw on the HEA Supply and Demand 2024/2025 model, HEA Student Survey responses in 2023 and 2024, and self-reported data from Higher Education Institutions (HEIs) to the HEA. Additional data sources, such as the Building Information Report (a report from a database of PBSA planning information prepared for the HEA), and data from the Residential Tenancies Board (RTB), were also considered.¹⁶

Supply estimates regarding the number of students accommodated in the wider private rental sector are inherently challenging as data is limited and RTB private rental registrations do not identify whether the tenant is a student. In addition, student survey responses are skewed towards first and second-year students. As a result, some assumptions are necessary to build up a composite picture of exiting accommodation arrangements. Data provided by the HEA Student Survey results in 2023 and 2024 suggests that 80,982 students live at home with 18% of this cohort facing lengthy commutes of over three hours daily. Adding this cohort to the existing group of students living away from home means, at present, two in every three students currently enrolled in public HEIs require on or close to campus accommodation.

¹⁶ RTB, available at <https://rtb.ie/register-tenancies/register-a-tenancy/how-to-register-a-student-specific-accommodation-ssa-tenancy/#register>

Figure 3. Supply of Student Accommodation 2023/2024



Furthermore, full time undergraduate and postgraduate student numbers are projected to grow to 243,499 by 2035. To meet these demands an additional 42,000 student beds will be required over the period 2026–2035. This figure addresses lengthy commutes currently faced by approximately 15,000 students as well as the projected demographic growth in student numbers to 2035.

DFHERIS will work with the HEA, individual HEIs and the RTB to enhance available data for future iterations of supply and demand estimates.

4.3 Supply Pipeline

At present, around 14,279 (mainly private) PBSA beds have received planning permission but have not progressed, with viability concerns consistently cited as the key barrier.

Monitoring Market Trends

To support informed decision-making regarding PBSA development trends, a systematic monitoring of the national pipeline of PBSA developments will be maintained. Rental markets are dynamic and can be influenced by external factors such as inflation and housing supply pressures. DFHERIS will collaborate with DHLGH and the RTB to survey rent in areas surrounding HEIs in order to gain a comprehensive understanding of how new PBSA developments affect local rental markets. The insights gathered will help inform future policy decisions.

Key Actions

Action	Task	Owner
1 Understanding Supply and Demand of Student Accommodation	The HEA will conduct periodic surveys to systematically collect data on student housing, travel options, and associated costs. This data will inform policy development, resource allocation, and student support services.	- DFHERIS - HEA
2 Research rental dynamics around HEI campuses	Research impact of newly developed PBSA on rental prices in adjacent communities located near HEIs.	- DFHERIS - DHLGH/RTB - HEA
3 Maintain Market Intelligence	Track national pipeline of PBSA	- DFHERIS - HEA

5. Strategic Pillar 1

Viability and Supply

Pillar One focuses on activating supply of 42,000 student beds, including On and Off Campus PBSA and Rent-a-Room beds over a ten-year period to meet the projected levels of demand. This will be achieved by creating the environment to attract private investment into the sector and by promoting Rent-a-Room accommodation as an efficient use of existing housing stock.



5.1 Market Wide PBSA Viability Levers

To activate the development of additional student accommodation beds across Ireland, several policy levers and mechanisms are being applied:

Rent Reform

Government has approved changes to rental sector legislation¹⁷ which will permit the rent setting of **new** PBSA at market rates with annual rent increases permitted and linked to inflation, as measured by the Consumer Price Index (CPI) rather than the Harmonised Index of Consumer Prices (HICP) from 1 March 2026.

- For **new** PBSA supply, rent increases in the first two years will be linked to CPI, with no 2% cap where the development commenced after the 10th June 2025. Rents may reset to market level again at the end of each three-year period.
- To protect students, given the annualised cycles of university life, students in **existing** PBSA will continue to benefit from rent control protections for a further three years and will not face any rent resetting to market rent before March 2029. The first rent setting on or after 1 March 2029, can reset rent to market rates and thereafter, at the end of each 3 year period. For the other two years in each 3 year period, the rent increase restriction applies (2% or rate of inflation (CPI), whichever is lower).

To bolster compliance and transparency, DFHERIS will collaborate with DHLGH and the RTB to assist in its role in the regulation of student-specific accommodation.

Changes in VAT on sale of new apartments

Budget 2026 introduced a measure to reduce VAT from 13.5% to 9% on the sale of new apartments including PBSA. Effective from 7 October 2025 to 31 December 2030 this measure is expected to have a positive impact on the viability of privately developed student accommodation across Ireland by providing an exit strategy for developers who do not wish to retain ownership of the PBSA in the long term.

It sends a strong signal to developers and institutional investors that the Government is committed to stabilising the fiscal environment for residential development and attracting capital into the student housing sector.

The estimated cost of the first year of this VAT reduction is €250m rising to an estimated €390m by 2030 as housing targets increase. This measure will help to bridge the viability gap for PBSA and will help activate some of the 14,279 beds that currently have planning permission.

Design Standards for Apartments, Guidelines for Planning Authorities (2025)

In July 2025, Minister for Housing, Local Government and Heritage James Browne and Minister of State for Local Government and Planning John Cummins published the new Design Standards for Apartments, Guidelines for Planning Authorities (2025).

The Guidelines apply to all housing or mixed-use developments that include apartments. Specific Planning Policy Requirement 8 of the guidelines, applies to PBSA and includes specific provisions relating to requirement for ensuite bathrooms and space allocation in kitchen/ living and dining areas, and is expected to improve the viability of PBSA developments by providing a basic level of accommodation given the proximity to wider amenities on campus.

Planning and Development (Amendment) Act 2025

The Planning and Development (Amendment) Act 2025,¹⁸ which came into force on 1 August 2025, represents a strategic update to Ireland's planning system. Its primary focus is to accelerate the delivery of housing and optimise the use of existing planning permissions. It allows modifications to existing permissions without a new planning application and permits extensions of planning duration for un-commenced developments. These elements reduce delays and will support the unlocking of stalled projects.

¹⁷ Residential Tenancies (Miscellaneous Provisions) Act 2026, available at; <https://www.irishstatutebook.ie/eli/2026/act/3/enacted/en/pdf>

¹⁸ Planning and Development (Amendment) Act 2025 available at <https://www.irishstatutebook.ie/eli/2025/act/9/enacted/en/html>

The measures set out above are expected to have a significant impact on the development of PBSA. In addition, the reduction in VAT on sales is likely to stimulate a significant increase in new development, including but not limited to some of the 14,279 units which already have planning permission. Private developer-led output, supported by RPZ reform, modifications to standards, and VAT reductions, are expected to make a significant contribution to the overall target of 42,000 student beds by 2035.

5.2 Public HEI Specific PBSA Viability Levers

In addition to the measures set out above, further levers may be needed to stimulate private sector investment in PBSA on or near to campus.

While traditional universities, University College Dublin, Trinity College Dublin, University of Galway, University of Limerick, Dublin City University, University College Cork and Maynooth University have a combined total of in excess of 15,600 on-campus student beds, none of the Technological Universities or Institutes of Technology have any PBSA with the exception of South East Technological University which has 426 publicly owned student beds.

Given the scale of investment envisaged to achieve the level of output required to 2035, private sector funding will be essential to future development of on or near to campus student accommodation. Due to budgetary constraints and statutory debt limitations, HEIs may be unable to finance large-scale projects through traditional public funding or direct borrowing. Collaboration with the private sector offers a strategic alternative by transferring the responsibility for development financing to the private sector.

The following levers may be considered, where necessary, to support private sector investment:

Standardised Design Model

In June 2025, the *Design Guide for State-Sponsored Student Accommodation* (Design Guide¹⁹) was published, setting clear, research-informed standards for publicly supported PBSA projects, in response to the 2023 Residential Construction Cost Study, which recommended the adoption of standardised templates and costing models to reduce development costs and streamline project execution.

The Guide outlines minimum specifications for key living spaces and promotes flexibility, efficient space use, sustainability, and is aimed at improving consistency, cost efficiency, and delivery timelines across new PBSA. The Design Guide allows for single study bedrooms without ensembles with minimum required area of 8m², shared bathrooms, flexibility in the mix of room types, and sets out minimum standardised requirements for kitchen/dining/living spaces. Key elements have been incorporated into the Design Standards for Apartments, Guidelines for Planning Authorities 2025,²⁰ issued by the Minister for Housing, Local Government and Heritage in July 2025. The Minister for Housing, Local Government and Heritage has signalled his intention to prepare a draft National Planning Statement for approval of Government under section 25 of the Planning and Development Act 2024, with an associated strategic environmental assessment, to replace the Design Standards for Apartments Guidelines.

The Design Guide supports cost efficiency, and flexibility using repetitive layouts, replicable and repeatable structural grids with stacked service cores.

The Guide also enables the use of Modern Methods of Construction (MMC) which provide an innovative approach to building with a focus on speed, efficiency, and sustainability. By utilising techniques such as prefabrication, modular construction, and panellised systems, MMC allows for faster delivery, improved quality control, and reduced on-site disruption. These methods also support environmental goals through reduced waste, lower embodied carbon, and greater design efficiency. The Strategy will support the greater use of Modern Methods of Construction to drive efficiencies.

¹⁹ Design Guide for State-Sponsored Student Accommodation, DFHERIS, June 2025 available at https://assets.gov.ie/static/documents/Design_Guide_for_State_Sponsored_Student_Accommodation.pdf

²⁰ Design Standards for Apartments, Guidelines for Planning Authorities 2025, Department of Housing, Local Government and Heritage, July 2025 available at https://assets.gov.ie/static/documents/Planning_Design_Standards_for_Apartments_080725_FINAL.pdf

State supported public PBSA projects will have regard to the *Design Guide for State-Sponsored Student Accommodation*. It is intended that additional typologies will be added to the Standardised Guidelines for State Sponsored PBSA that may include studios and communal space.

The Design Guide reflects extensive engagement with students, providers, and experts, and delivers a ready-to-use template that can fast-track the roll-out of modern, affordable student housing nationwide.

HEI Owned Land for Student Accommodation

Providing HEI owned sites opens up the development of land which would not otherwise be available for housing. Providing a site to a developer under a long-term license, with the necessary safeguards, can reduce cost and enhance the attractiveness to the developer. Technological Universities have already entered into license agreements to facilitate the development of educational buildings on HEI owned land through the Higher Education Programme of Public Private Partnerships. HEIs in countries such as the UK, USA and Australia have utilised various financial mechanisms and delivery vehicles such as, Design, Build, Finance, Operate (DBFO) methods to develop PBSA on public land. In Ireland, HEIs have secured planning permission for on-campus PBSA development of around 2,359 student beds and are actively developing further proposals which could be advanced through private sector delivery.

Site Servicing

In addition to the provision of HEI owned lands, the Strategy will support the development of sites so that publicly funded HEIs can provide services and access to sites on campus. This work could include establishment of site topography, ground conditions, availability and capacity of services, with the option of further enabling works as required. Such works will reduce risk and enhance the attractiveness of sites for private sector development.

DFHERIS will consider financing early-stage activities by publicly funded HEIs, such as campus master planning, site assessments, remediation, and infrastructure provision, as part of a wider programme of measures to unlock private sector development potential on HEI owned sites.

Nomination Agreement

A nomination agreement is a formal contract between a university and a private accommodation provider. It allows the university to “nominate” a certain number of students to live in a privately operated residence, often in exchange for guaranteed occupancy and operational input. Such agreements are common in PBSA developments internationally.

A nomination agreement enables a university to guarantee housing for students while operators benefit from consistent occupancy and reduced marketing costs. However, failure to supply the agreed number of students can lead to a HEI becoming liable for the associated rental payment.

Traditional Universities have borrowing powers which enable them to take on the contingent liabilities associated with nomination agreements and borrowing under Section 38 of the 1997 Universities Act. However, Technological Universities do not yet have government-approved powers under Section 21 of the Technological Universities Act, 2018²¹ on Borrowing, Guarantees and Underwriting. In order to fully avail of the potential of nomination agreements, DFHERIS will work with Departments of Finance, Public Expenditure, Infrastructure, Public Service Reform and Digitalisation, and the HEA, to design a borrowing framework of appropriate financial mechanisms, controls and safeguards to enable Technological Universities to enter into nomination agreements, on a strictly limited basis. This process may be informed by the involvement of NewERA, who provide financial and commercial advice to Government Ministers and Departments. Each individual nomination agreement will require approval from the Minister for Public Expenditure, Infrastructure, Public Service Reform and Digitalisation and the Minister for Finance. It is proposed that there will be an initial pilot phase to allow DFHERIS, with the assistance of NewERA and the HEIs, to learn how best to implement this policy instrument and to provide a preliminary assessment of its effectiveness, cost-efficiency and wider impacts.

In view of the growing demand for student accommodation, DFHERIS will support the development of nomination agreements for new PBSA developments only, as the intention of this policy instrument is to trigger increased supply.

²¹ Technological Universities Act 2018, available at www.irishstatutebook.ie/eli/2018/act/3/enacted/en/html

5.3 HEI Student Accommodation Programme

To ensure a consistent approach to the delivery of State-supported student accommodation, DFHERIS in conjunction with the HEA established a national Technological Sector Student Accommodation Programme to enable Technological Universities and Institutes of Technology to submit proposals for student accommodation on, or near, their main campus location.

Under the Strategy this programme will be expanded to include traditional universities to allow the whole sector to deliver on the growing demand for student accommodation across Ireland. The programme is underpinned by a HEA review of the levels of demand for student accommodation at a national and regional level, undertaken in collaboration with individual HEIs.

The first phase of the programme concluded in 2024 with the submission of strategic assessment reports by HEIs for different options for the development of student accommodation projects on and off campus. These included HEI led-development, private sector development, HEI/private sector partnerships, leasing, and nomination agreements.

The second phase of the programme involves the development and evaluation of the initial preliminary business cases (as defined by the Infrastructure Guidelines) comprising of a narrative, and financial and economic models. This work will be informed by an external assessment of potential delivery mechanisms, which the HEA has commissioned. This assessment considered the full range of potential delivery mechanisms and evaluated them, informed by industry expertise, availability of State funding, and speed of response, and will be further tested through a market engagement exercise (see below). Finalised preliminary business cases informed by this market engagement are expected during 2026.

The evaluation of preliminary business cases is being informed by a market engagement exercise to assess the interest in developing PBSA under licence on HEI owned land and also on privately owned land supported by nomination agreements.

Projects that successfully meet the requirement of the preliminary business case stage will be invited to participate in a structured engagement process between HEI's and the development community to enable private sector investment. Insights from this engagement will support the development of contractual relationships between developers and HEIs. Where appropriate, these arrangements may incorporate elements such as standardised design, provision of HEI owned land, site servicing, and nomination agreements to enable private development of on-campus PBSA. Market engagement and subsequent expressions of interest process will be undertaken on a phased basis in 2026.

DFHERIS intends to engage the support of the National Development Finance Agency (NDFA) for advice in relation to arrangements proposed under the market engagement exercise and programme development. The NDFA provides financial advice to State authorities in respect of those public investment projects which are referred to it, with a capital value over €75m. It also procures and delivers Public Private Partnership (PPP) projects as requested by State authorities, including the Higher Education PPP Programme on behalf of DFHERIS.

State Aid Compliance

A review of the HEI Student Accommodation Programme will be undertaken to ensure that it is managed having full regard to the provisions of State Aid legislation. Through open, transparent, and competitive processes utilising tools such as market testing and open expressions of interest (EOIs), the programme will operate under normal market conditions and offer equal access to all qualified participants. This will not only support compliance with state aid rules but will also help identify the most cost-effective and efficient PBSA solutions for each HEI.

5.4 Rent-a-Room Relief Scheme

In addition to PBSA, Rent-a-Room accommodation is an important source of student beds and will be actively promoted through this Strategy.

Rent-a-Room accommodation is supported through the *Rent-a-Room Relief Scheme*.²² The Scheme allows homeowners to earn up to €14,000 per annum by renting out a room in their owner-occupied residence without incurring a tax liability.

To widen participation in the Scheme, in May 2022 the Department of Social Protection introduced a disregard on this income for means tested social welfare payments and in May 2023 this disregard was extended to social housing tenants. In January 2024, the Government approved legislation to disregard up to €14,000 in Rent-a-Room income when assessing eligibility for Medical Cards or GP Visit Cards. This change was introduced under the Health Miscellaneous Provisions Bill 2024.

Revenues' *Cost of Tax Expenditures*²³ Report which estimates cost in terms of revenue forgone, as well as the numbers who availed of reliefs and exemptions, reported that in 2023 16,580 taxpayer units claimed the Rent-a-Room income exemption at a cost of €42.1 million, an increase of 2,400 taxpayer units and €6.3 million in revenue forgone from 2022.

Recognising the importance of Rent-a-Room accommodation as an established part of the supply landscape, the Department will continue to conduct annual communications campaigns to encourage uptake of the Rent-a-Room Relief Scheme and HEIs will be tasked with promoting and supporting the effective operation of Rent-a-Room accommodation in their areas.

Rent-a-Room Protections: Voluntary Regulatory Framework

Because owner-occupied properties fall outside the remit of the RTB, the Department has developed a voluntary regulatory framework and sample licence agreement to assist both homeowners/primary tenants and students who wish to avail of the scheme.²⁴ These documents highlight the key issues to consider when renting and offering a room for rent. All HEIs should carry sample agreements on their websites and encourage their usage.

Rent-a-Room Voluntary Quality Assurance Framework

Some HEIs operate internal advertising platforms that are monitored and vetted by their accommodation teams. Others use external services such as Student Pad, which enable institutions to review listings and respond to student and landlord feedback. This form of quality assurance serves as a safeguard against potential abuse and helps maintain a reliable standard of accommodation.

HEIs will be tasked to support student specific Rent-a-Room listings through a structured, voluntary framework using an in-house or software platform for listing student accommodation.

Research on participation in the Rent-a-Room Scheme

Rent-a-Room accommodation plays a significant role in the student housing sector. To gain clearer insights into this source of supply, the Department will conduct research on participation in the Rent-a-Room Scheme.

The research will:

- Explore the motivations of individuals who choose to rent out rooms under the scheme.
- Identify the barriers or deterrents preventing others from participating.
- Assess the role of institutional support (e.g. HEIs web based platforms) in influencing participation.
- Provide recommendations to improve uptake and ensure quality for students.
- Further quantify adoption levels of Rent-a-Room.
- Understand scale and causes of unsatisfactory outcomes which will inform an update of the voluntary regulatory framework.

²² Office of the Revenue Commissioners, available at www.revenue.ie/en/personal-tax-credits-reliefs-and-exemptions/land-and-property/rent-a-room-relief/index.aspx

²³ Cost of Expenditures, Office of the Revenue Commissioners. (August 2025)

²⁴ Rent-a-Room – Voluntary Regulatory Framework available at www.gov.ie/en/department-of-further-and-higher-education-research-innovation-and-science/publications/rent-a-room-voluntary-regulatory-framework/

5.5 Sustainable Commuting

The Strategy complements the objectives of the emerging “Moving Together”²⁵ Transport Demand Management Strategy, which aims to curb excessive transport demand.

In support of this, the student accommodation strategy empowers HEIs to enhance their capacity for evaluating sustainable transport. This includes leveraging data-driven insights to assess student mobility and support efficient commuting patterns.

The Strategy supports the expansion and diversification of student accommodation options and complements the upcoming National Sustainable Mobility Plan in recognising that the availability of student accommodation is a significant factor influencing student commuting patterns.

Pilot Project: Campus Commute Reimagined

A pilot project will be developed to establish a framework for increased collaboration between HEIs, the national transport authority (NTA), local authorities, and transport operators to improve sustainable commuting options for students.

Key components include:

- **Strategic engagement with the NTA:** formalised channels for consultation and planning to align HEI transport needs with national mobility strategies.
- **Active participation in the smarter travel scheme:** promotion of walking, cycling, and public transport through awareness campaigns, infrastructure improvements, and behavioural incentives.
- **Localised coordination:** engagement with regional transport providers to optimise routes, schedules, and access points serving HEI campuses.
- **Data-driven planning:** collection and analysis of commuting patterns to inform targeted interventions and monitor impact.
- **Student and staff involvement:** inclusion of campus communities in co-designing solutions to ensure relevance and uptake.

The 2024 HEA Student Survey found a significant proportion of students face lengthy commutes from home, which can undermine ability to fully participate in academic and extracurricular life. This Strategy aims to support students to be accommodated at home where commuting time is less than 3 hours in total. Commutes lasting more than three hours are considered excessive and demonstrate the need for accommodation closer to campus. This need has been factored into demand projections in Chapter 4, above.

HEIs currently participate on the Smarter Travel Campus Programme²⁶ which is a behaviour change programme working with Third Level Campuses to implement voluntary Campus Travel Plans that promote and encourage sustainable and active commuting. Under the Strategy, all publicly funded HEIs will be required to participate in the Smarter Travel Mark Programme, and to develop and implement sustainable commuting policies as part of their estate and accommodation strategies. This will include measures to support active and public transport.

Through its initiatives, the Strategy will contribute to reducing transport demand on and around campuses by fostering a culture of sustainable mobility across the sector.

²⁵ Department of Transport, available at www.gov.ie/en/department-of-transport/consultations/public-consultation-moving-together-a-strategic-approach-to-the-improved-efficiency-of-the-transport-system-in-ireland/

²⁶ TFI Smarter Travel for Campuses is an initiative of the National Transport Authority available at www.nationaltransport.ie/tfi-smarter-travel/smarter-travel-campus/

Key Actions: Viability

Action	Task	Owner
4 Campus Sustainable Commuting Policy	HEI to develop and support a campus Sustainable Commuting Policy.	• DFHERIS • HEA • HEIs
5 Sustainable Commuting	A pilot project will be developed to establish a framework for increased collaboration between HEIs, the National Transport Authority (NTA), Local Authorities, and transport operators to improve sustainable commuting options for students.	• DFHERIS • D/Transport • HEA
6 Standardised Design	Develop additional typologies to add to the Standardised Guidelines for State Sponsored PBSA and modules such as the following to be considered; • studios • communal space	• DFHERIS • HEA
7 Support Universities to address student accommodation needs	Design a limited framework under S.21 of the TU Act, 2018 for nomination agreements to support the development of student accommodation.	• DFHERIS • D/Finance • DPER
8 Serviced Sites	Subject to State aid clearance, support publicly funded HEIs to prepare strategic sites for PBSA development and assess feasibility of funding private sites developments near campus to improve viability of projects and accelerate delivery.	• DFHERIS • HEA
9 Rent-a-Room Relief Communications Campaign	Develop communications campaign to support the uptake of the Rent-a-Room Relief Scheme.	• DFHERIS • HEIs
10 Research on participation in the Rent-a-Room Relief Scheme	To gain clearer insights into this accommodation segment, the Department will conduct research on participation in the Rent-a-Room Relief Scheme.	• DFHERIS
11 Conduct market engagement exercise	DFHERIS will seek advice from the NDFA in relation to structured market engagement on the HEI student accommodation programme. HEA will input as required to help enable this engagement.	• DFHERIS • HEA

6. Strategic Pillar 2

Affordability Supporting Students

The second pillar of the Strategy addresses affordability. It supports the *National Access Plan* (NAP), to promote equity of access to higher education.

It seeks to assist individuals from underrepresented and disadvantaged groups to participate fully in third-level education.

It aims to provide targeted financial support directly to students regardless of whether they are Living at Home, in Rent-a-Room accommodation, Private Rental or public or private PBSA.



6.1 DFHERIS Affordability Levers

Affordability of student accommodation has declined considerably in recent years. An Independent Review of the Student Grant Scheme by Indecon Consultants²⁷ published in 2022 noted that accommodation was the largest single cost facing students, accounting for around 32% of a student's monthly expenditure.

Accommodation costs have increased considerably in the intervening years, and the 2023 and 2024 HEA student surveys suggest that on average students are paying €700 per month on accommodation, a figure well in excess of the average SUSI standard maintenance grant rate for those whose primary residence is more than 30km from the HEI they attend. This strategy points to a need to reverse this decline. To ensure alignment with the lived experience of students, future iterations of the student survey will continue to track total student accommodation costs. DFHERIS will seek to increase supports through the estimates process to reverse the decline in affordability for NAP students.

DFHERIS will continue to advocate across Government to retain and extend policies that improve the affordability of accommodation for all students.

DFHERIS has developed a number of affordability supports targeted at specific cohorts of student. The levels of support provided will be targeted for increase through the annual estimates process.

Student Grant Scheme

The Student Grant Scheme, administered by Student Universal Support Ireland (SUSI), is the main financial support scheme for students studying in approved full-time third-level courses in Ireland covering both further and higher education.

Student grants are divided into Maintenance Grants and/or Fee Grants. The student maintenance grant is a contribution towards the living costs of a student, and the scheme provides for different levels of maintenance support, depending on the applicants means which are defined within varying income thresholds and adjacency criteria (distance from your primary residence to college). To be eligible for a grant, an applicant's household income must be within the income thresholds set out in the Student Grant Scheme (*Figure 4*).

Students living further from their institutions may incur significantly higher costs for transport and accommodation. These expenses can act as a barrier to participation and retention in higher education. The Student Grant Scheme accounts for this by providing a higher rate of grant known as a "non-adjacent" grant.

The Non-Adjacent Maintenance Grant is awarded to eligible students whose primary residence is 30km or more from their institution and represents a critical support mechanism for those facing elevated costs associated with travel, accommodation, and daily living. The grant will be targeted for increase in future estimates processes building on the additional €10.5m allocated in Budget 2026, bringing the total allocation for non-adjacent students to €146.5m for the 2025/2026 academic year.

The Non-Adjacent Maintenance Grant is awarded across five grant bands depending on household reckonable income. Budget 2026 increased all non-adjacent rates by at least €200 from September 2026, with a pro-rata increase for the 2026 academic year of between €111–€239, benefitting nearly 30,000, plc, undergraduate and postgraduate students.

²⁷ Review of the Student Grant Scheme, Indecon, 2022 available at: www.indecon.ie/assets/files/pdf/report_on_indecon_review_of_the_student_grant_scheme.pdf

Figure 4. SUSI Non-Adjacent Maintenance Grant Rates

Grant Band	Income Threshold 2025/26	Recipients 2025/2026	Non-Adjacent Rate 2024/2025	Budget 2026 Annual Increase	Non-Adjacent Rate 2026/2027
Special Rate	€28,600	8,747	€7,586	€350	€7,936
Band 1	€47,010	14,889	€4,292	€430	€4,722
Band 2	€48,270	764	€3,332	€200	€3,532
Band 3	€51,040	1,523	€2,502	€200	€2,702
Band 4	€58,470	3,905	€1,666	€200	€1,866

Note: The Student Grant Scheme is a demand led scheme, and participant estimates are based on the number of grant applicants paid for the 2024/ 2025 year. Income thresholds increase slightly for households with four or more dependents or more relevant persons in further/higher education.

Prioritising funding measures for SUSI non-adjacent special rate recipients is a data-driven, socially responsible, and policy-aligned measure to target supports for students who commute long distances or who must rent when attending college. It ensures that financial supports are directed to students who face additional barriers to accessing and succeeding in higher education, thereby reinforcing the principles of fairness, inclusion, and opportunity at the heart of Ireland's education system.

Students on an approved full-time course can deduct up to €8,424 in income earned outside of term time. Known as Holiday Earnings, this deduction applies to income earned during the Easter, Summer and Christmas holidays and is disregarded for the purposes of establishing household income.

PATH 2 – 1916 Bursary

The 1916 Bursary Fund was established in 2017 to support innovative approaches to deliver the ambitions, goals, objectives, actions, and targets of the National Access Plan.

The Bursary is a financial award to encourage the participation and success of students who are most socio-economically disadvantaged and from groups most under-represented in higher education, including:

- Students from underrepresented socio-economic backgrounds,
- Students with a disability,
- Students who are carers,
- Students who are QQI or further education award holders,
- Lone and/or teen parents in receipt of a long-term means-tested social welfare payment,
- Members of the Irish Traveller and Roma communities,
- First-time mature student entrants and second chance mature students and persons from ethnic minorities who are lawfully present in the State.

The total State funding for the bursary has increased significantly, from €1.25 million in 2020/21 to approximately €8.76 million in 2024/25.

In the 2024/25 academic year, there were around 2,698 bursary recipients. Of these, 1,392 were new recipients, categorised across three Tiers. The cost associated with these new recipients is approximately €3.58 million.

Figure 5. 1916 Bursary new recipients 2024/2025

Bursary Category	Value of Bursary	New Recipients 2024/25
Tier 1	€5,000 per annum	400
Tier 2	€2,000 per annum	200
Tier 3	€1,500 once off	792
Total		1,392

Student Accommodation Assistance Scheme

To remove accommodation as a barrier to higher education for priority group students, DFHERIS secured Dormant Accounts Funding in November 2023 to pilot the Student Accommodation Assistance Scheme for Traveller, Roma, and care-experienced students.

In 2024/2025 €412,000 was allocated and eighty-five students benefited from the scheme, including sixty-four from Traveller/Roma backgrounds and twenty-one care-experienced learners.

Building on its success, €600,000 in Dormant Accounts funding was secured for 2025/2026 to continue the Student Accommodation Assistance scheme, providing financial support to students living independently while attending third-level education.

First round applications for the 2025/2026 Student Accommodation Assistance scheme have been approved. Over €630,000 was allocated in November 2025, to benefit one hundred and seventeen students including sixty-four Traveller students, fifteen Roma students, and thirty-eight students with experience of the care system.

Drawing on insights from the 2024 and 2025 pilot programme funded by the Dormant Accounts Fund, the Student Accommodation Unit will design a targeted support initiative for Roma, Traveller, and care-experienced students. This programme will provide bursaries to assist with accommodation costs. Funding will be sought through the Estimates process with a view to launching the initiative in the 2027/2028 academic year.

Student voice is essential in shaping policy that truly reflects lived reality. The Department wishes to express its sincere thanks to the students who have shared their personal experiences with us. Behind every policy decision and funding allocation is a student navigating financial pressure, caring responsibilities, disability, or social disadvantage. Their experiences show that accommodation supports are not just financial measures; they provide stability, dignity, and a genuine chance to succeed.

The following testimonies are powerful examples of the difference targeted support can make.

Student Voice Care-Experienced Student²⁸

“I spent some time in Tusla care as neither of my parents were able to take care of me. I was given no support when I aged out at 18 as I hadn’t been under their care for 2 years.

I started college at 20 and considered dropping out multiple times in my first semester because there was no way I could afford Dublin rent and do a heavy full-time course. My grades suffered because I had to work instead of attending classes and tutorials. And when I was there, I couldn’t concentrate because my mind was on whether I could afford rent that month, top up my leap card, and even afford food. The accommodation grant had a huge impact on my life. It freed up my mind to focus on my grades. And it offered a sense of security and stability I hadn’t felt since I left foster care.

This fund is a big step in helping me achieve my plans of becoming a chartered accountant one day. Without the fund, there is no way for me to finish schooling as I receive no support from my parents, and I don’t qualify for any social benefits.

Becoming a chartered accountant means a lot of assignments, studying, and classes. Things I can’t commit to while working full time.

This fund has benefited my mental health as well. I no longer carry the stress of worrying about rent. And I’m able to now only work part time at my job during weekends and focus on school during the week.”

²⁸ Details of the Tusla Aftercare Services available at www.tusla.ie/services/alternative-care/after-care/what-are-aftercare-services

Student Voice

Traveller Student

“I want to express how deeply the Accommodation Assistance Fund has changed my life. Without it, going to college simply wouldn’t have been possible. Knowing that my rent was guaranteed gave me peace of mind – it removed one of the biggest burdens I faced and allowed me to focus on my studies instead of worrying constantly about where we’d live or how I’d manage.

The support has helped me not just financially, but mentally and physically too. Having that stability meant I could begin to heal, to rest properly, and to study without constant fear. It gave me breathing space – something I hadn’t had in a long time. As a single mother from the Travelling community, the challenges I’ve faced are unique and often invisible. Financial support from parents is traditionally cut off once you’re married, but I entered an unsafe marriage where I wasn’t supported either. Now I’m on my own, raising my child without family help, trying to build a future from the ground up.

Because of this fund, I now have a small bit of extra money to do something I couldn’t before – buy my child a toy, something simple but meaningful. That may not sound like much, but to us, it means everything. I just want to say thank you. This support isn’t just about rent. It’s about survival, dignity, and the chance to build a better life – for me and for my child.”

The Department will seek to mainstream the programme through the Estimates process, reflecting its strong commitment to removing accommodation as a barrier to higher education and ensuring equitable access for all learners.

Student Assistance Fund

The Student Assistance Fund (SAF) provides financial support to full or part-time students who are experiencing financial difficulties while attending college. Students can apply for the Student Assistance Fund to help with either temporary or ongoing financial difficulties. The Student Assistance Fund is designed to provide a source of financial support in addition to a student grant.

In the 2023/2024 academic year, the fund provided support to over 22,000 students, amounting to over €19 million. Of this, more than €16.2 million was allocated to students for accommodation and transport-related costs. This means that over 83% of the total funding was directed toward addressing students’ housing, utilities, and mobility needs.

Included in SAF for 2023/2024 and 2024/2025 was an additional €440,000 allocated for assisting students in funding emergency accommodation.

The Student Assistance Fund is administered on a strictly confidential basis by individual HEIs.

Figure 6. Student Assistance Fund Accommodation and Transport Expenditure 2023–2024

Category	Total Expenditure
Transport	€3,439,466
Rent/Accommodation	€6,149,764
Heating/lighting/food and other utility bills	€6,608,551

Fund for Students with Disabilities (FSD)

The purpose of the Fund for Students with Disabilities (FSD) is to assist higher education institutions in ensuring students with disabilities have the necessary assistance and equipment to enable them to access, fully participate in and successfully complete their chosen course of study. Funding can be used to provide supports and accommodations in any of the following broad categories: assistive technology equipment and software (including student training), non-medical helpers (e.g., personal assistants, notetakers), academic/learning support, supports for students who are deaf or hard of hearing (e.g., sign language interpreters, SpeedText) and transport support. As part of a package of supports under this fund it is recognised that some students with disabilities have significant, additional travel costs to pay to get to and from their HEI. In 2024 the fund provided €8.04m to support 19,488 students. The fund for 2025 in Higher Education is €9.5m. In 2023/2024 105 students with a disability received funding towards their transport costs.

Short-Term Activation Programme

As part of the Short-Term Activation Programme, 1,000 student beds are being delivered across a number of publicly funded Higher Education Institutions (HEIs). A minimum of 30% of these newly delivered beds will be reserved for priority groups identified under the National Access Plan and offered at below-market rental rates.

This targeted measure is expected to benefit almost three hundred students, each receiving an estimated €3,000 annual reduction in rent.

6.2 Other State Supports

Aftercare Supports

A range of tailored supports are available to help young people leaving State care to access and succeed in higher education. The *National Aftercare Policy for Alternative Care*²⁹ was developed in the context of the Child Care Amendment Act 2015³⁰, Section 2 places a statutory responsibility on Tusla to provide for an assessment of need for young people and young adults who meet the eligibility criteria for an aftercare service. This assessment of need sets out their individual needs, including pathways into education and training which subsequently informs the Aftercare Plan.

The aftercare allowance amounts to €300 per week and is dependent on the eligible young adult attending an accredited education course, third level course or training programme as outlined in the young adults Aftercare Plan. The allowance is provided to cover a young adults day to day costs, including accommodation as they progress in their chosen accredited course or training program. The total financial support for the aftercare allowance in 2024 was €25.6 million.³¹

Back to Education Allowance

The Back to Education Allowance (BTEA) provides income support for jobseekers and others in receipt of certain social protection payments who pursue courses of education at further or higher level. The focus of the scheme is to assist people to improve their qualifications and as a result improve their access to sustainable employment. Employment Personal Advisors and Job Coaches support jobseekers to participate in the Back to Education Allowance as part of the development of their personal progression plan.

At the end of December 2024 there were 1,747 BTEA beneficiaries in Higher Education and 1,864 beneficiaries in Further Education and Training. In 2024, total expenditure for BTEA including Further and Higher Education beneficiaries was €32.16 million.

²⁹ National Aftercare Policy for Alternative Care, Tusla 2017, available at www.tusla.ie/uploads/content/4248-TUSLA_National_Policy_for_Aftercare_v2.pdf

³⁰ Child Care Amendment Act 2015, available at www.irishstatutebook.ie/eli/2015/act/45/enacted/en/html

³¹ Tusla Annual Report 2024, available at www.tusla.ie/annual-report-2024/

Rent Tax Credit

The Rent Tax Credit, introduced in the Finance Act 2022, became available for the 2022 tax year, and eligibility was expanded in the Finance (No.2) Act 2023 to include Rent-a-Room accommodation paid by parents for children attending approved courses.

Figure 7.

Tax Year	Single Person	Jointly Assessed Couple
2022–2023	500	1,000
2024–2025	1,000	2,000

In Budget 2026 the Rent Tax Credit was extended for a further three years until the end of 2028. Revenue has reported in its Cost of Tax Expenditures Report that 315,030 taxpayer units benefited from the credit for 2023 at a cost of €183.5 million.³² While it is not possible to identify student or parent of student beneficiaries of this credit it is likely that the vast majority of the 119,166 students currently in Rent-a-Room accommodation, PBSA or private rental accommodation could benefit from the credit either directly or through their parents.

Figure 8. DFHERIS Annual Student Support Summary Table

Support	Year	Total Expenditure € million	Number of Beneficiaries	Comment
Student Grant (Non-Adjacent Rate)	2025/2026	€146.5 ³³	29,828	Extra €10.5m, secured in Budget 2026 and Students this academic year will also see a pro-rata increase from January 2026.
Student Assistance Fund	2023/2024	€19.3	22,292	Over 80% of the total funding was directed toward addressing students' housing and mobility needs.
Path 2. 1916 Bursary	2024/2025	€8.76	2,698	In the 2024/25 academic year, there are around 2,698 bursary recipients. Of these, 1,392 are new recipients, categorised across three Tiers. The cost associated with these new recipients is approximately €3.58 million.
Student Accommodation Assistance	2024/2025	€0.41	85	Permanent funding will be sought through the Estimates process.

³² Cost of Tax Expenditures, Office of the Revenue Commissioners, August 2025, available at www.revenue.ie/en/corporate/documents/statistics/tax-expenditures/costs-tax-expenditures.pdf

³³ For 2025/26 Non-Adjacent Maintenance grants the estimated figure is €146.5m for the period up to and including June 2026 as the allocation for 2026 has not been finalised.

Figure 9. Other Government Annual Student Support Summary Table

Support	Year	Total Expenditure € million	Number of Beneficiaries	Comment
Rent Tax Credit	2023	€183.5	315,030	Most of the 119,166 students in PBSA or private rentals could benefit from the credit.
Back to Education Allowance	2024	€32.2	3,697 ³⁴	Includes 1,747 in Higher Education
Tusla After Care Support	2024	€25.6	2,196 ³⁵	Up to 78% of Aftercare beneficiaries relates to participants in Training and Education

Key Actions: Affordability

Action	Task	Owner
12 Rent-a-Room Quality Assurance Framework	To safeguard students from frauds and substandard accommodation the Strategy will enable HEIs to support Rent-a-Room listings through a structured voluntary framework using an in-house or software platform to manage listings.	• DFHERIS • HEIs
13 Increase Student Grant	The Strategy will target additional support to recipients of the non-adjacent maintenance grant as it assists students who live furthest from their HEI and are from low-income households.	• DFHERIS
14 Establish Student Accommodation Assistance Scheme	Permanent funding will be sought through the Estimates process.	• DFHERIS • DPER
15 Maintain Student Assistance Fund	Continue to maintain the Student Assistance Fund that supports students facing financial difficulties.	• DFHERIS

³⁴ The total enrolment of 3,697 includes 86 students participating in Springboard and ICT Skills programmes. The majority of full-time enrolments comprise 1,864 learners in Further Education and Training (FET) and 1,747 in Higher Education.

³⁵ Tusla Performance & Activity Report Q4 2024, 78% (1,721/2,196) of those 18-22 years inclusive in receipt of an aftercare service at the end of Q4 2024 were in education/ accredited training.

7. Implementation Action Plan

An implementation plan will be developed to deliver on the commitments in the Strategy.

To support the implementation of the student accommodation strategy, the Department will establish an Inter-Departmental Implementation Group. This group will serve as a central coordinating body, ensuring that all relevant stakeholders, including government Departments, higher education institutions, housing providers, and student representatives, have timely access to detailed information on student accommodation initiatives and progress.

The Department will also conduct a formal review of the implementation plan every three years, in collaboration with stakeholders. This review will assess progress, identify challenges, examine supply/demand, and inform any necessary adjustments to ensure the effective delivery of the plan's objectives.

7.1 HEI Specific Student Accommodation Strategy

Each HEI will be tasked with developing a Student Accommodation Strategy in line with National Strategy for approval by its Governing Authority.

HEI strategies should set out their objectives and approaches to support development and operation of on or near campus PBSA, their engagement with private developers and operators of student accommodation, their promotion of supply and uptake of Rent-a-Room accommodation and their facilitation of commuting for students who choose to remain living in their family home. The Strategy recognises that HEIs are at varying stages of maturity in implementing these practices, while some universities have already made significant progress, others are just beginning their journey. HEIs should develop accommodation strategies to address;

Management of PBSA

- PBSA allocation principles including affordability and prioritisation for specific cohorts (e.g. first-year students, targeted groups under the NAP, international students, distance weighting).

Quality Standards

- Quality standards, covering safety, maintenance, and living conditions.
- Governance and operational procedures, outlining roles, responsibilities, and review mechanisms.

Supply and Utilisation

- Monitoring new PBSA developments as part of data collection.
- Supporting development of PBSA on and near campus.
- Monitoring the demand for accommodation.
- Promotion and support for Rent-a-Room accommodation for new tenants.
- Reporting on uptake of Rent-a-Room accommodation through standardised platforms.
- Reporting on HEI owned PBSA utilisation in and outside of term time.

Pastoral Support

- Pastoral support for students in Student Accommodation either owned, leased or in nomination agreement arrangement.
- Student engagement, ensuring student voices are included in planning and feedback processes.
- Engagement with private PBSA operators regarding pastoral care.

Commuting

- Development and implementation of sustainable transport strategies.

As a HEI establishes its accommodation function, there is a critical need to build internal capacity to support good governance, financial probity, sustainable growth, quality service delivery and operational resilience.

HEIs should identify core competencies required and appoint Accommodation Officers or develop training programmes and onboarding pathways for existing staff enabled by the capacity development funding outlined below.

7.2 HEI Capacity and Capability

The Department recognises that developing and implementing the different policy responses for student accommodation across the sector will require a dedicated function within each publicly funded HEI.

To facilitate the implementation of student accommodation policies and integrated sustainable transport policies, the department will support capacity development within publicly funded HEIs to enable the establishment of a dedicated function responsible for HEI specific student accommodation strategy and sustainable commuting policy development. Each HEI will ensure sufficient resources are in place to implement its student accommodation strategy.

DFHERIS and the HEA will support HEIs to describe and develop the necessary capability to carry out the student accommodation functions within each HEI.

7.3 Targets and Evaluation

Each HEI will be required to report annually to the HEA on progress against strategy. DFHERIS and the HEA will work with HEIs to develop a set of indicators to support annual reporting.

The objective of Pillar One of this Strategy is to increase supply of student PBSA beds, expand availability and uptake of Rent-a-Room accommodation and to support a sustainable commute to campus for students, staff, and visitors.

Achievement of these objectives will be measured by;

- PBSA Delivery Rate: Number of new beds delivered.
- Rent-a-Room Participation Rate: Number of registered Rent-a-Room providers and student placements.
- Impact on commuting times and frequency.

The objectives of Pillar Two of this Strategy focus on delivering targeted and effective interventions to make accommodation options more affordable. Achievements will be measured by the scale of funding and number of beneficiaries across each of the schemes.

Key Actions

Action	Task	Owner
16 HEI Student Accommodation Strategy and Policy	HEIs to develop their own Student Accommodation Strategy and associated Policy	• Publicly Funded HEIs
17 Establish an Inter-Departmental Implementation Group	Establish an Inter-Departmental Implementation Group on student accommodation as a co-ordinating mechanism to progress on delivering actions in the plan.	• DFHERIS
18 Build Capacity	DFHERIS and the HEA will support HEIs to describe and develop the necessary capability to carry out the student accommodation functions within each HEI.	• DFHERIS • HEA • HEIs

Appendix A: Consultative Process

The development of a robust and responsive Student Accommodation Strategy hinges on meaningful and sustained engagement with a diverse range of stakeholders.

Throughout the Strategy’s formulation, the Department prioritised consultation and collaboration, recognising that the success of any student-focused initiative depends on understanding the lived experiences, concerns, and expertise of those directly and indirectly affected.

Stakeholder feedback also informed key workstreams such as the Technological Sector Student Accommodation Programme and the Standardised Design Study, ensuring these initiatives are grounded in practical realities and best practices.

Inter-Departmental Working Group on Student Accommodation

The Inter-Departmental Group was established to examine the student accommodation requirements on a regional and national level for students attending publicly funded HEIs.

Membership included:

- DFHERIS,
- Higher Education Authority,
- Department of Finance,
- Department of Public Expenditure, Infrastructure, Public Service Reform and Digitalisation,
- Department of Housing, Local Government and Heritage,
- Department of Transport.

Expert Advisory Group on Student Accommodation

The expert advisory group was established to assist the work of DFHERIS, by providing up to date industry knowledge and experience, in the development of the Department’s new student accommodation strategy.

The group consists of industry and agency experts on matters relating to student accommodation.

Membership included:

- DFHERIS,
- EY,
- The Housing Agency,
- Nominee of Irish Institutional Property,
- UCD,
- Ireland Strategic Investment Fund,
- Higher Education Authority.

Stakeholder Engagement and Acknowledgements

Throughout the development of the Strategy, Department officials have met with a wide variety of stakeholders.

The Department would like to acknowledge all the following organisations who provided valuable assistance, information, or material that contributed to the development of this Strategy.

- AHEAD
- Aontas na Mac Léinn in Éirinn (AMLÉ formerly USI)
- Atlantic Technological University
- Construction Industry Federation
- County and City Management Association (CCMA)
- Department of Children, Disability and Equality
- Department of Enterprise, Trade and Employment
- Department of Finance
- Department of Health
- Department of Housing, Local Government and Heritage
- Department of Public Expenditure, Infrastructure, Public Service Reform and Digitalisation
- Department of Rural and Community Development and the Gaeltacht
- Department of Social Protection
- Department of Transport
- Dublin City University
- Dublin City University Students' Union
- Dun Laoghaire Institute of Art and Design & Technology
- Dundalk Institute of Technology
- Elkstone
- EPIC (Empowering People in Care)
- EY
- Global Student Accommodation
- Harrison Street
- Higher Education Authority
- Housing Finance Agency
- Ireland Strategic Investment Fund
- Irish Institutional Property
- Irish Universities Association
- Land Development Management Agency (LDMA)
- Local Authorities
- Local Link
- Mary Immaculate College
- Maynooth University
- Munster Technological University
- National College of Art & Design
- National Development Finance Agency
- National Disability Authority
- National Parents Council
- National Transport Authority
- New Economy and Recovery Authority
- Office of the Revenue Commissioners
- Pavee Point
- Property Industry Ireland
- QMPF
- Residential Tenancies Board
- Royal Institute of the Architects of Ireland
- Royal Irish Academy
- South East Technological University
- St Angela's College
- Student Body (through student survey and standardised design)
- Technological Universities Association
- Technological University Dublin
- Technological University Shannon: Midlands Midwest
- The Housing Agency
- The Smart Off-site Association (SOsA)
- Threshold
- Trinity College Dublin
- Tusla
- University College Cork
- University College Dublin
- University College Dublin Students' Union
- University of Galway
- University of Limerick
- University of Limerick Students' Union

Appendix B: Table of Actions

Action	Task	Owner
1 Understanding Supply and Demand of Student Accommodation	The HEA will conduct periodic surveys to systematically collect data on student housing, travel options, and associated costs. This data will inform policy development, resource allocation, and student support services.	• DFHERIS • HEA
2 Research rental dynamics around HEI campuses	Research impact of newly developed PBSA on rental prices in adjacent communities located near HEIs.	• DFHERIS • DHLGH/RTB • HEA
3 Maintain Market Intelligence	Track national pipeline of PBSA.	• DFHERIS • HEA
4 Campus Sustainable Commuting Policy	HEI to develop and support a campus Sustainable Commuting Policy.	• DFHERIS • HEA • HEIs
5 Sustainable Commuting	A pilot project will be developed to establish a framework for increased collaboration between HEIs, the National Transport Authority (NTA), Local Authorities, and transport operators to improve sustainable commuting options for students.	• DFHERIS • D/Transport • HEA
6 Standardised Design	Develop additional typologies to add to the Standardised Guidelines for State Sponsored PBSA and modules such as the following to be considered; • Studios • communal space	• DFHERIS • HEA
7 Support Universities to address student accommodation needs	Design a limited framework under S.21 of the TU Act, 2018 for nomination agreements to support the development of student accommodation.	• DFHERIS • D/Finance • DPER
8 Serviced Sites	Subject to State aid clearance, support publicly funded HEIs to prepare strategic sites for PBSA development and assess feasibility of funding private sites developments near campus to improve viability of projects and accelerate delivery.	• DFHERIS • HEA
9 Rent-a-Room Relief Communications Campaign	Develop communications campaign to support the uptake of the Rent-a-Room Relief Scheme.	• DFHERIS • HEIs
10 Research on participation in the Rent-a-Room Relief Scheme	To gain clearer insights into this accommodation segment, the Department will conduct research on participation in the Rent-a-Room Relief Scheme.	• DFHERIS

Action	Task	Owner
11 Conduct market engagement exercise	DFHERIS will seek advice from the NDFA in relation to structured market engagement on the HEI student accommodation programme. HEA will input as required to help enable this engagement.	• DFHERIS • HEA
12 Rent-a-Room Quality Assurance Framework	To safeguard students from frauds and substandard accommodation the Strategy will enable HEIs to support Rent-a-Room listings through a structured voluntary framework using an in-house or software platform to manage listings.	• DFHERIS • HEIs
13 Increase Student Grant	The Strategy will target additional support to recipients of the non-adjacent maintenance grant as it assists students who live furthest from their HEI and are from low-income households.	• DFHERIS
14 Establish Student Accommodation Assistance Scheme	Permanent funding will be sought through the Estimates process.	• DFHERIS • DPER
15 Maintain Student Assistance Fund	Continue to maintain the Student Assistance Fund that supports students facing financial difficulties.	• DFHERIS
16 HEI Student Accommodation Strategy and Policy	HEIs to develop their own Student Accommodation Strategy and associated Policy.	• Publicly Funded HEIs
17 Establish an Inter-Departmental Implementation Group	Establish an Inter-Departmental Implementation Group on student accommodation as a co-ordinating mechanism to progress on delivering actions in the plan.	• DFHERIS
18 Build Capacity	DFHERIS and the HEA will support HEIs to describe and develop the necessary capability to carry out the student accommodation functions within each HEI.	• DFHERIS • HEA • HEI

Appendix C: List of Acronyms

AHEAD

AHEAD is an independent non-profit organisation working to create inclusive environments in education and employment for people with disabilities. The focus of its work is further education and training, higher education, and graduate employment.

CSO

Central Statistics Office is an agency that gathers and analyses population and other data, through the national Census and other surveys.

DCDE

Department of Children, Disability and Equality. The Department's mission is to enhance the lives of children, young people, adults, families, and communities, recognising diversity and promoting equality of opportunity.

DFHERIS

Department of Further and Higher Education, Research, Innovation and Science. The Department is responsible for policy, funding and governance of the higher and further education and research sectors and for oversight of the work of the state agencies and public institutions operating in those areas.

DHLGH

Department of Housing, Local Government and Heritage

DPER

Department of Public Expenditure, Infrastructure, Public Service Reform and Digitalisation. The Department's goal is to serve the public interest through sound governance of public expenditure and by leading and enabling reform across the Civil and Public Service.

DRCD

Department of Rural and Community Development. The Department's mission is to promote rural and community development and to support vibrant, inclusive, and sustainable communities throughout Ireland.

DSP

Department of Social Protection. The Department's mission is to promote active participation and inclusion in society through the provision of income supports, employment services and other services.

ETBs

Education and Training Boards are responsible for delivering primary, post-primary and further education in their regions, and developing appropriate further education and training programmes in conjunction with SOLAS.

FSD

Fund for Students with Disabilities. The FSD provides funding to Higher Education Institutions to assist them in offering supports and services to students with disabilities to enable them to access, fully participate in and successfully complete their chosen course of study. The FSD also supports students on PLC, further education, and training courses.

HE

Higher Education at universities, technological universities, institutes of technology, and other education institutions, with qualifications of Levels 6–10 on the NFQ.

HEI

Higher Education Institution. A university or technological university (TU), institute of technology (IoT), college of education or other institution offering higher educational qualifications.

HEA

Higher Education Authority. The HEA leads the strategic development of the Irish higher education and research system. Its objective is to create a coherent system of diverse institutions with distinct missions which is responsive to the social, cultural, and economic development of Ireland and its people and which supports the achievement of national objectives.

IUA

Irish Universities Association. Representative body for Irish universities and associated colleges.

NAP

National Access Plan, a Strategic Action Plan for Equity of Access, Participation and Success in Higher Education 2022–2028.

NDA

National Disability Authority. Independent statutory body that provides information and advice to the Government on policy and practice relevant to the lives of people with disabilities.

NewERA

New Economy and Recovery Authority (NewERA) provides financial and commercial advice to Government Ministers and Departments in relation to their shareholdings in State companies across a range of sectors.

NDFA

The NDFA provides financial advisory, procurement and project delivery services to State authorities on public infrastructure projects.

PATH

Programme for Access to Higher Education is a strategic funding programme that supports equity of access to higher education. It funds innovative initiatives through targeted strands to improve participation and retention among priority groups, aligning with National Access Plans.

PBSA

Housing specifically constructed for students. Unlike converted properties, PBSA offers dedicated communal amenities and is usually located near universities or on campus for convenience.

Rent-a-Room Accommodation

This refers to a housing arrangement where a student rents a bedroom in a private home. The student usually shares communal areas such as the kitchen, living room, and bathroom with the household. This type of accommodation often includes options for meals (full board or half board).

RTB

Residential Tenancies Board is an independent public body that regulates Ireland's rental sector.

SAF

Student Assistance Fund. A fund that provides financial assistance for higher education students who experience financial difficulties while attending college.

STAP

Short-Term Activation Programme is the Government policy to provide State assistance to stimulate the development of new student accommodation for public HEIs.

Student Grant Scheme

This statutory means-tested grant scheme, provided for under the Student Support Act 2011, is the main scheme for supporting students attending approved further and higher education courses.

SUSI

Student Universal Support Ireland. A business unit of the City of Dublin ETB, which is the appointed awarding authority for the statutory-based Student Grant Scheme.

TSSAP

Technological Sector Student Accommodation Programme is a government initiative to address the shortage of student housing by creating a framework for building, leasing, or refurbishing accommodation for students at Technological Universities and other higher education institutions.

TUA

Technological University Association. Representative organisation for the technological higher education sector.

Tusla

The Child and Family Agency is now the dedicated State agency responsible for improving wellbeing and outcomes for children.

